



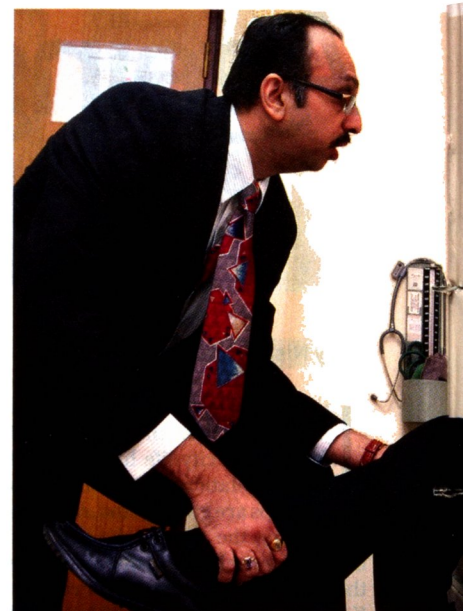
FALGUNI SHAH, 34
Patient Of: Rheumatoid Arthritis
Treatment: Hip replacement
 Housewife Shah was under a great deal of stress when rheumatoid arthritis set in at the age of 30. For one year she was bedridden to the extent that she would cut vegetables on bed. "The pain was so severe that I could not even turn while sleeping," she says. All her day-to-day activities, like shopping for groceries and going out with her husband, stopped. "I was so embarrassed to go out with my husband as people would stare at me as I walked like an old woman," she says. During the worst period, depression kicked in but her husband and father helped her through it. After a hip replacement in November 2009, she's back on her feet.

Across 15 Indian cities, osteoarthritis trounced common diseases like diabetes and hypertension. The worst-hit are the women in this age group. Obesity, pollution, alcohol consumption, stress, smoking and a lack of exercise are now ageing the country's young. Rapid urbanisation and sedentary lifestyles have seen young hips and joints decay to such an extent that replacement surgery is the only option. "Surgeons are replacing joints of patients aged between 25 and 40 because they are completely damaged. This was unheard of a decade ago. We were only operating on those in their 50's and 60's," says Dr Kaushal Malhan of Fortis Hospital in Mumbai.

Traditionally, osteoarthritis would hit those above 55 and reach a peak around 65 to 70. Now, the starting age for osteoarthritis has come down and the end stage of the disease is being seen in 40-year-olds. Dr Shreedhar Archik gets four to 10 osteoarthritis cases daily in the OPD. "Around 10 per cent of these are young. I've seen a 15 per cent rise each year in the number of young patients," says Archik, who is attached to Lilavati Hospital and Shushrusha Hospital in Mumbai.

There is no one uniform cause for osteoarthritis. It is linked to various factors that lead to an erosion of the cartilage, which cushions the joint. There could be a genetic element or too much body weight on the joint may also result in osteoarthritis. It is also connected to trauma, such as an accident of some kind. A person may develop arthritis in their old age if their cartilage had been damaged in a fall in the childhood. Contracting tuberculosis is another reason.

It's not only osteoarthritis that is wreaking havoc on the young. Rheumatoid arthritis is also surfacing



DR KAUSHAL PAUL/www.indiatodayimages.com

and progressing faster due to lifestyle triggers. Rheumatoid is a stress-related, inflammatory disease in which there is a genetic element. It can affect any age group. "It may be a genetic disease but may not manifest until you are subjected to one of those triggers," says Dr Malhan. Falguni Shah contracted rheumatoid arthritis at the age of 30 when she was under huge family stress. Within three years it had deteriorated so rapidly that she was bedridden for a year and finally had to go under the scalpel.

India has more than 56 million osteoarthritis cases and 0.8 per cent of all arthritis cases are rheumatoid. The knees seem to be under most pressure with about 90 per cent of India's arthritis patients suffering from frail knee joints. Eight out of 10 children are obese today and the extra body load causes wear and tear of the knee joints. At the other extreme are young fitness fanatics who are putting pressure on their knee joints during high impact gym routines. "In India there is more knee osteoarthritis than hip so all this extra weight and impact makes osteoarthritis progress faster," says Dr Sushil Sharma, chairman of the Arthritis Foundation of India and as-



"ANXIETY AND STRESS PLAY A BIG PART IN RHEUMATOID ARTHRITIS AND TODAY'S YOUNGSTERS ARE UNDER A LOT OF STRESS."

DR RAHUL SHAH, Consultant Orthopaedic & Knee Surgeon